An Intricate Spar, the Fairest of Duels
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An Intricate Spar, the Fairest of Duels

by Mirror_of_Roses

Summary

"All this romance talk is making me wonder what it’s like.” Phainon sighs dramatically, shoulders slumping. “Unfortunately, there’s not a soul I’d be able to court, being a busy Chrysos Heir and all. Unless, of course…” He tips his head forward, a playful smirk on his face. “I courted you, Prince Mydei?”

A loud gasp in front of them followed by a series of even louder gasps behind them painfully reminds him that they are, in fact, very much in public. He doesn’t need to look around to know that everyone nearby has stopped to watch.

There’s no way Phainon actually forgot the world existed around them. He did this on purpose to mess with him, didn’t he? Mydei knows he’s utterly shameless, but this takes the cake.

Notes

has this been done yet??? i saw the prompt for this on tumblr and thought it was neat so i ran with it like an ambitious football player. you can see it here https://www.tumblr.com/starcurtain/773356540763750400/phaidei-tho

if the chapter count changes as i keep adding to the story, don't be surprised. i'd be surprised if it didn't lmao

enjoy!

Accidental Challenge (Mydei POV)

Marmoreal Market is best enjoyed at least two floors off the ground.

At least, that's why Mydei personally selected this exact rooftop to be his "quiet time" space. A few people have it in them to climb up to the rooftops, but they're rarely loud. The complete opposite of the streets below.

It's the day of the week where most prefer to either do their weekly shopping or go out with friends. Okhema's citizens are bustling about with their shopping bags, fawning over a beautiful display, grabbing a refreshing drink or two—

Approaching him from behind…?

Mydei sighs. There go his peaceful ten minutes in total. "Don't bother, Deliverer. I know it's you."

"Do I ever get to greet you first up here?" He can hear Phainon's wounded tone from across the way. Phainon's footsteps haven't even made it to the building he's on yet. "You really are something else."

He stares pointedly at the view as he waits for Phainon to reach him. A rainbow trail swirls in the distance, but it pales in comparison to the sight of Kephale, waterfalls of gold dripping from their hands. "No one else comes here."

Phainon grins as he takes his place at Mydei's side. "I only swing by when I know you're around."

"When you need something from me, you mean." Mydei looks at him sidelong.

"So harsh!" Phainon laughs. "I can't say you're wrong this time. I have a bit of a favour to ask of you."

“Which is?” It better not take up the rest of the afternoon.

Phainon shifts his weight from one foot to the other, his grin turning into a sheepish smile. “I thought I’d take your advice to relax more, since apparently I’m ‘too busy running around doing everyone’s errands to breathe.’ Tribbie and Aglaea have been busy lately, so I asked Castorice about hobby recommendations and she suggested reading. Which, of course, is a good idea, except…”

Mydei watches him trail off and glance away. He thinks Mydei is going to say no, so he’s dancing around it until Mydei gets fed up, isn’t he? The thought makes him scowl. “Except what? You can’t read?”

“I *can.*” Phainon huffs a short sigh. “I just don’t know where to start and need advice.”

Advice? From him? Mydei blinks. “You didn’t think to ask Castorice earlier? She’d have better recommendations than I would.”

“I did, but I doubt I’d find much enjoyment in history books and legends.” Phainon shakes his head. “She did say I might like fiction novels, but I don’t know the first thing about those.”

Mydei gives him a flat look. “And you think I do.”

Phainon clasps his hands together and brings them up to his chest, pleading with everything he has. “All I need is a second pair of eyes while I look for a good book. I promise I’ll stop at one. It shouldn’t take too long if there’s two of us looking. Then you can come back up here and watch the sky to your heart’s content. Please, Mydei?”

In their years of knowing each other, Mydei’s found that whatever Phainon calls a “quick jaunt” tends to morph into a whole ordeal. Setbacks, problems, detours, and the like. He could drag Mydei along to get a glass of water and they’d end up spending an entire morning hunting meat for dinner because the kitchens ran low and they were short staffed.

Knowing this, he’s disappointed when he realizes that he truly has nothing better to do today and somehow has the energy to put up with any nonsense that comes their way. In theory, at least.

He doesn’t bother to answer. He simply turns around and starts making his way back to the ground.

“You’re the best,” Phainon cheers, following close behind. “If we’re not done by dinnertime, I’ll make it up to you. Food’s on me.”

“You should be paying anyway,” Mydei retorts. “This isn’t my wheelhouse and you know it.”

“Then we’ll both be learning something new. Isn’t that exciting?”

Mydei rolls his eyes as they begin to walk across a roof. “You’re paying.”

“Alright, I’m paying.” Phainon raises his hands in surrender, his voice taking on a teasing lilt. “But I’m also picking the restaurant. Beggars can’t be choosers, after all.”

“So you’re going to pick my brain, then my dinner. How generous.”

“What, a man can’t have cravings? You can order whatever you want, I won’t stop you!”

“Whatever I want?” Mydei challenges as they descend the last flight of stairs. “I hope you’re ready, Deliverer.”

Phainon laughs but can’t hide the nervous edge in it. “Please don’t say it like that.”

The transition from quiet rooftops to crowded streets is smooth, if a little harsh on his patience. Every voice could be one that reaches out to Phainon and gets them sidetracked. The sea of people parts around them, but he remains vigilant and ready to slip away if anyone talks to them. It must show on his face, by the way Phainon grabs his shoulder and tugs him back with a disarming smile.

“Walk any faster and we’ll miss all the book stalls,” Phainon says, pointing at the nearest one. “Speaking of which, want to check that one out first?”

As if he has a choice. “Sure.”

Phainon leads the way and they stop in front of a stall resembling a vastly oversized book nook more than anything else. It’s no library, but they’re well-stocked and boast a variety of genres. The owner gives them a wave and a halfhearted glance from her own book, then does a blatant double take, staring at them with wide eyes and rapt attention.

“Good afternoon, miss.” Phainon raises a hand in greeting. “How are you today?”

“Lord Phainon?” the shopkeeper breathes, eyes bouncing between the two of them. “And Lord Mydei? What— what brings you both here?”

“A growing interest in literature,” Phainon says breezily. “Could you point me to your most popular novels?”

Not only does she point him to them, she also grabs each one and explains their selling points one by one in a rush of giddy excitement. Phainon seems to have this well in hand, so why is Mydei even here?

He ignores their one-sided conversation in favour of picking up a random book, careful not to damage it with his claws. He reads the back cover. Some sort of fantasy story, he thinks. Mysterious dungeons popping up all over the world, hidden sources of power, an intriguing magic system, mature themes, a dash of revenge. He turns the book to view it from the side. This is the first volume.

It *sounds* interesting.

Before he can debate whether or not he’ll have time to read it, Phainon calls his name.

“Found something already?” Phainon peers down at the book with interest. “You can get it for yourself, you know.”

“I might.” Mydei spots the bundle in Phainon’s hands and hums. “That was fast. And here I thought you’d spend the whole afternoon deliberating.”

“Oh, this?” Phainon holds both books up. “It’s a duology. It might be good for me to read something I normally wouldn’t.”

“Which is… anything?”

Phainon snorts. “The lovely owner here says this is the romance series of the year. The plot isn’t too deep, but it’s supposed to be a thrilling adventure that sweeps you off your feet! Just the right thing to settle down between missions with, don’t you think?”

Mydei stares blankly at Phainon, then the books. That isn’t much to go off of, in his opinion, but reading something without much substance while sandwiched between potentially life-ending expeditions might not be a bad idea for an overthinker like him. Even the Deliverer needs to decompress.

“What’s it about?” he asks.

Phainon wiggles the first book. “In this one, the two protagonists meet at a masquerade ball open to the entire kingdom. They fall head over heels and try finding each other’s identities afterwards. Turns out they’re both nobility and they have to jump through some serious hoops to impress each other’s parents.” He shakes the second one. “This is whatever comes after that. I’m not spoiling myself by reading the synopsis.”

“It can’t be that much of a spoiler.” Mydei reaches for it, only for Phainon to raise it high above his head.

“Nope! Not one soul is telling me what happens before I’m ready.”

“I wasn’t *going* to tell you.”

“But if you see, then every time I look at you, I’ll think about how you know something I don’t.”

Mydei’s eyebrow twitches. “I’m not even reading the books. I’ll forget what I saw soon enough.”

“Uh huh,” Phainon muses, obviously not convinced. “With your exceptional memory?” He tucks it in the crook of his elbow and flips to the first book’s table of contents. He chuckles softly. “These chapter names are so sappy.”

Mydei leans over to get a glimpse and swiftly agrees. “I’m shocked the author didn’t run out of ideas.”

“They must be a real romance fan to name thirty chapters.” Phainon flips the page and his eyes widen, impressed. “Look, there’s even a map.”

Mydei hums in acknowledgment, skimming over the strange names.

Phainon shifts at his side and they meet eyes. “Say, were there any fancy dating rituals in Kremnos?”

The question gives him pause. “Yes,” Mydei drawls, suspicious. For an idle curiosity, Phainon looks *far* too interested. “Why?”

“Oh, you know. All this romance talk is making me wonder what it’s like.” Phainon sighs dramatically, shoulders slumping. “Unfortunately, there’s not a soul I’d be able to court, being a busy Chrysos Heir and all. Unless, of course…” He tips his head forward, a playful smirk on his face. “I courted you, Prince Mydei?”

A loud gasp in front of them followed by a series of even *louder* gasps behind them painfully reminds him that they are, in fact, very much in public. He doesn’t need to look around to know that everyone nearby has stopped to watch.

There’s no way Phainon actually forgot the world existed around them. He did this on purpose to mess with him, didn’t he? Mydei knows he’s utterly shameless, but this takes the cake.

Mydei straightens his back and clears his throat, a confident hand on his hip. “Since your declaration was made formally, with due courage, and in accordance with the expected customs, I will fairly consider your proposal — *if* you prove yourself worthy. In which case, I will accept your suit.”

There it is: the signature look of panic Phainon only has when he trips up and has to maneuver out of embarrassment. His jaw is clenched, his lips pressed firmly, and his eyes are just slightly unfocused.

Mydei expects that, but not the awkwardness of his laugh, and especially not the faint blush on Phainon's cheeks.

"I'm getting the full experience, aren't I?" Phainon sinks to one knee and takes his hand, giving it a light squeeze before pressing a delicate kiss to his knuckles. When he raises his head, he gives Mydei a dazzling smile. "I shall do my utmost to win your heart."

Before Mydei can even begin to process what those words made him feel, a sharp thud from the crowd draws both their attention. A woman collapsed on the ground, her friend trying to shake her awake and the teleslate in her hand opened to the camera app. Around half the people here have their cameras out, now that he looks at them. The rest either have their hands pressed to their mouths, whispering to one another, or are just plain shocked.

He glares at them all. The smart ones scatter immediately, the rest apparently need to be told, "Get lost. Do you have nothing better to do?"

Not bothering to see if they disperse, he opens his mouth to say something to Phainon, but the expression on the other's face stops him in his tracks. Phainon has properly stood up, still holding Mydei's hand, and he seems to be an odd mixture of both flustered and joyful.

He wasn't serious about that whole spectacle, was he? Why does he look like he is? Mydei swallows his sudden nerves.

"What?" Mydei says, trying to keep his voice even. "Cut that out."

"Cut what out?" Phainon tips his head to the side like an innocent puppy. Like he didn't publicly challenge Mydei to the most intricate of spars. The brute.

Mydei groans and shoves his book at Phainon's chest. "Just buy these damn things and let's get out of here. You owe me."

He stalks off, leaving Phainon to deal with the flabbergasted shop owner.

Maybe it was a bad idea to go along with Phainon on this errand. Maybe it wasn't. What matters is that he went and somehow, things turned out this way.

Part of him hopes he doesn't have to teach Phainon the Kremnoan customs line by line. If Phainon wants to mess around like that, he's going to have to work for it. The rest of him wants to see how far Phainon's willing to take this charade. For experimental purposes.

"Mydei, wait!" Phainon calls, rushing to catch up to him. He carries a small bag in his hands. "Still want to do dinner?"

Mydei huffs, barely slowing down. "After what you put me through? You'd better be feeding me."

Despite the sharp words, Phainon's grin lights up his entire face.

A Feast of Delicacies (Kyros POV)

Chapter Notes

> MET MY IMAGINARY VALENTINE'S DAY DEADLINE LET'S GOOOO
>
> if none of you get the chance to have a nice dinner with your valentine this year then maybe this chapter is enough to make up for it idk
>
> I'm gonna put the character pov in future chapter titles! i think it'll be more exciting that way, especially if you guys get the fic update email :D
>
> enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kyros isn’t normally one for gossip, but even he heard about the proposal that started going viral a week ago. The patrons at Marmoreal Diner can’t stop squealing about it. They show each other the same photos and videos over and over, occasionally at full volume, to the point where he swears he can hear it in his sleep.

Well, he’s happy for them. They’re Chrysos Heirs, they work so hard putting their lives on the line for Okhema and Amphoreus as a whole, they deserve to have good things in their lives. And it’s always better to hear about the latest “power couple” than the impending doom and despair from the black tide.

“So Lord Phainon is really going for it,” a woman tells her friend as Kyros approaches to bring them their order. “I thought he was only ever serious about being our hero.”

“Come on, you don’t loudly announce you’re going to date someone unless you mean it,” the friend says before thanking Kyros for the dishes with a

polite smile. She sits up, snatches up her knife, and starts cutting her dromas steak into neat pieces. “Especially when you’re both celebrities.”

“Will that be all?” Kyros asks, setting down their drinks.

“Yes,” the first woman answers, then turns back to her friend. “Have you heard how that courtship thing is going yet? All I’ve heard is that they’ve been *seen* together.”

Kyros slinks off to the side, close enough to overhear but not enough to be accused of eavesdropping. The other guests are well taken care of, he can spare a moment.

“I saw a picture of him with some rare flowers two days ago,” the blonde one says conspiratorially. “I’ve never seen anything like them. They must be special. He looked like he was in a hurry too— he was blurry in the photo.”

“Really?” The brunette gasps excitedly. “How romantic! Do you think Lord Mydei appreciated them? He wouldn’t throw them out since he said he’d be fair about the whole thing.”

“More than that.” The blonde scans their surroundings before leaning in, speaking almost too quietly for Kyros to hear. “Call it a theory— a popular theory, mind you— but I think it’s all a pretense. They’re totally engaged. Buying time to properly plan the wedding, if you ask me. See what the public thinks of their relationship before making it official.”

“What?!” the brunette yells, bolting upright and nearly knocking her food off her lap.

“Shush!” the blonde hisses, a finger to her own lips.

The brunette’s eyes widen as she covers her mouth with both hands.

“A theory,” the blonde repeats, stabbing her steak and shoving the meat in her mouth. “We’ll see how long it lasts.”

The brunette stares pointedly in the distance and gasps again. “D-Daphne, let’s change the subject,” she rushes to say.

“Why?” comes the lazy reply.

Kyros very quickly sees why. The “why” has just turned the corner and is heading straight for the diner, much to his delight.

“Good afternoon, Lord Phainon and Lord Mydei,” Kyros calls to them once they’re closer.

“Good afternoon,” Phainon replies, in high spirits as usual.

Mydei simply nods in acknowledgment. Ah, Kyros knows what’s likely going through his mind: based on his body language and expression, he’d rather spend this meal with Phainon in private, not in public. A common look Kyros has seen during romantic holidays, especially on the shy types. It looks grumpier on Mydei’s face.

Maybe that blonde woman was right after all. They’ve been together for quite some time.

“Seating for two?” Kyros prompts, giving absolutely none of his thoughts away.

“Yes.” Phainon nods, already eyeing a more secluded area.

“Right this way, then.” Kyros leads them to that exact spot and waits for them to lay down before continuing. “Would you like a menu, your usual, or would you prefer to try something new?”

Phainon’s eyes light up. “Have you come up with any new dishes?”

Kyros’s smile morphs from polite to genuine. This is why Phainon is one of his favourite customers. He won’t take up too much of his time with the typical food ramblings, though. “I’ve been workshopping one for the past few days, but it isn’t finished yet. If it’s ready by your next visit, I would be honoured if you gave it a taste.”

“Next time for sure.” Phainon grins. “For today, I actually have a special request— one within reason, I assure you.”

He has a feeling that Phainon would never make an unreasonable request, so he nods. “Of course. What can I do for you?”

Phainon takes a quick glance at Mydei before answering. “What would you consider to be an extravagant meal of delicacies? One worthy of someone whose heart means more to you than anything else?”

Mydei scowls and reaches over to smack Phainon’s arm, hissing, “We. Are. In. Public.”

“That we are,” Phainon chirps. “Well, Kyros?”

Kyros clears his throat. He can feel the other guests staring this way. “I would recommend the Classical Platter, if it would suit your tastes. Are you both familiar?” He knows Phainon is, but can’t be sure about Mydei.

“I’ve heard of it from him,” Mydei says, gesturing to Phainon, “but I’m not familiar with the finer points.”

Everything in him wants to scream with excitement and jump for joy, yet nervousness pools in his stomach. As much of an honour as it would be to give a little food history lesson to not one, but *two* Chrysos Heirs at the same time, the last thing he wants is to set off Mydei’s impatience. The man probably just wants to have a nice meal with his beloved (potential beloved?) and be left alone.

It never hurts to ask. Rather, gently nudge. He swears he’s only slightly intimidated by Kremnos’s Crown Prince.

“I could tell you all you wish to know about the Classical Platter, if you don’t mind.”

The two of them share a look, wordlessly communicating.

“Do you want to?” Phainon’s eyes seem to ask as he tips his head to the side.

“Doesn’t matter to me,” says Mydei’s expression and nonchalant shrug.

“I think it’ll be fun,” Phainon’s growing smile suggests.

“Whatever you want,” the wave of Mydei’s hand dismisses him.

Phainon finally turns to Kyros. “We’d love to hear it. Please, enlighten us.”

Kyros wishes he could tip customers. He tries to keep himself from exploding in sheer jubilation. “It is our signature dish. Originally, it was a complex masterpiece with several dozen steps. I've greatly simplified it while retaining its main flavors, but the order you taste the ingredients in is still crucial—” Ah. He needs the actual food to continue. “Please, allow me to bring it out for you. We’ll make it fresh, of course, but it shouldn’t take more than a quint.”

“Take your time,” Phainon encourages. “Believe me, we’re not going anywhere.”

With a smooth bow, Kyros takes his leave and rushes to the kitchen. For such esteemed guests, it’s only right that the owner cooks this spectacular meal himself. The other three servers can pick up the slack.

As he gets started, only accepting “hand me the ingredients” help from the other chefs and nothing more, he wonders if his diner will gain even more popularity now that Phainon and Mydei have been seen here. Not only are they reclining, they’re also going to eat his signature dish in the recommended order. Any picture that people sneak will show a shining example of the dining experience he hopes to give every single guest.

They might not know it, but their extravagant date will undoubtedly improve business. He might be busy at all hours of the day, every table booked up and reserved because he’s been endorsed by the Chrysos Heirs.

And with more people comes more curious food enthusiasts. For the next few days, weeks if he’s lucky, Kyros anticipates that he’ll have the time of his life.

When he steps out of the kitchen, he finds Phainon and Mydei engrossed in their own conversation. Almost all the other tables have gone silent in favour of glancing their way and subtly eavesdropping, others opting to whisper instead of speaking at a normal volume. By Kephale, it's quiet enough for Kyros to hear the scuff of his own footsteps.

"I'm sorry, by the way." Phainon frowns, sighing in disappointment at himself. "I couldn't find more traditional Kremnoan food on such short notice, but I hope this counts as treating you to an extravagant meal of delicacies. If not, I'll have to get creative," he mutters the last bit.

"These are unique circumstances," Mydei says. "I'm the first to be courted *outside* of Kremnos."

"You do have a point." Phainon chuckles. "Still, the last thing I want is to lose points for trying to woo you, the Crown Prince, with such a deviation from your traditions. Your people would hunt me down and get on my case for sure!"

Mydei shakes his head with a scoff. "You'll lose points if you keep doubting yourself. Court me like you mean it or don't bother."

Kyros reaches their table then, a large tray with two platters in hand. He greets them with a polite smile as he sets down their food. "Thank you for waiting, gentlemen. Are you both ready to begin?"

Mydei eyes the platters with interest while Phainon responds for them. "We are, yes."

With that, Kyros swiftly unveils both servings of the Classical Platter in a rush of steam. Egg rolls line one side of the outer edge while flank steak glistens along the other. Peeled apple chunks doused in a rich amber sauce sit in the center. Phainon's eyes light up at the sight and even someone with a poker face like Mydei seems delighted, in his own quiet way. Kyros's heart swells with pride. This is what he loves most about his job, and he gets to share it with the illustrious saviours of Amphoreus. He might be too exhilarated to sleep tonight.

“Now, please enjoy the golden egg rolls on your right first— a mix of poultry egg rolls, aquarhino milk, and a special fruit sauce boiled over low heat, a perfect starter.”

Phainon practically leaps into the rolls, smothering his first one in fruit sauce and humming in satisfaction the moment he sinks his teeth in and the flavour bursts on his tongue. He beams up at Mydei, who takes more deliberate bites. “This is delicious! Isn’t it?”

Mydei chews slowly, as if assessing the layers of every mouthful. Eventually, he nods. “It is.”

They don’t need to eat all of them before moving on. All Kyros wants is to demonstrate the proper order, then leave them to their devices. So he gestures to their plates with a bright smile, physically glowing from the compliments.

“Next, please savour the main course— the juicy rocklamb rib meat on the left, charcoal-grilled in my secret sauce, a balance of nutrition and flavour.”

In the corner of his eye, he spots several people on both sides: some blatantly watching, some hiding behind furniture and decor, and a few sneaking a quick picture before shoving their teleslates into their robes. All of them are completely focused on Phainon and Mydei.

How strange that they can eat without noticing them. Aren’t they trained warriors? Legendary, even? They must know, must feel the countless eyes on them, must hear the not-so-subtle whispers of awe and amazement. Still, Kyros feels the overwhelming need to do something.

That feeling instantly dissipates when Phainon looks up and gives their audience a friendly wave. “Hello everyone!”

Kyros swears the tension spikes, then ebbs away as they all shyly wave back.

Poor Mydei looks like he wants to either throttle Phainon or throw him out the door. Kyros is grateful to not be on the receiving end of that. He clears

his throat and continues.

“Finally, we've got dessert— the freshest apples in Okhema paired with my upgraded cinnamon honey sauce, a delightful end to your meal.”

The first bite of apples is barely in their mouths when the entire crowd raises their hands, some waving to presumably get Kyros’s attention. When he turns his head, the bravest person states, “I’d like what they’re having.”

And the diner erupts with enthusiastic orders.

“The Classical Platter, right?”

“It must be amazing if the Chrysos Heirs are eating it!”

“How much is it? It can’t be that expensive.”

Kyros puts up a hand to stop them. They fall silent, leaning forward with anticipation. “It’s 1000 Balance Coins,” he says. “Please raise your hand if you’d like a Classical Platter.”

All of their hands stay high in the air. Twenty. Were there this many people before Phainon and Mydei showed up? His big break came sooner than he thought it would.

He’ll have to give the chefs and servers a bonus when they close.

“Don’t worry about us,” Phainon assures him, gracious as ever. “Thank you for the demonstration, Kyros. I hope these wonderful customers give you the same chance.”

Kyros takes a breath, nods in gratitude, and faces the crowd. “Twenty Classical Platters, coming up. Please return to your seats while we make them.”

~

The next few days pass in a whirlwind of activity. So many people come to his diner, he can barely keep up. He doesn’t even have time to browse the

web to get a semblance of just how *busy* he’s going to be. Instead, he relies on word of mouth from the customers.

“My aunts say they’re going to stop by with friends later today.”

“Wow, I can’t believe this is… better than my daughter made it out to be. Somehow. She talked like it serenaded her and whispered sweet nothings, but it’s dancing in my mouth! I think my heart is singing!”

“Did you hear the Phaidei Fanclub is organizing a Classical Platter Brunch for tomorrow? I’m thinking of going.”

“The… the what fanclub?”

While Kyros makes a point to stay out of *that* conversation, he wishes he had the chance to thank them personally. Maybe he’ll send a heartfelt card to the Chrysos Heirs with a few coupons.

Even if he knows they’ll tip him enough to make up the difference.

Chapter End Notes

> also THANK YOU for all the kudos and comments, holy shit I did not expect this many people to read this and show it so much love. i try so hard to respond to you all because it makes me so happy 😭😭😭
> you're all rockstars

Sinking Deeper (Phainon POV)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon can’t remember the last time he was so antsy in a bath.

Sure, they’ve held countless meetings in the Hero’s Bath and he’s been given harrowing missions in the process, but that’s the sort of stress he’s grown used to over the years. He and Mydei just returned from one such mission and before an hour ago, it was business as usual. Rush into battle, slay Titankin, provoke Mydei, get provoked in return, complete the mission, and come back to rest.

Now, though? The adrenaline’s long worn off and he’s left with the consequences of his actions.

He knows he’s the one who loudly, proudly declared his intention to court Mydei. He understands that that comes with spending time alone together, whether in private or in public. He’s given Mydei flowers, taken him to dinner, fought him enough times to make the most die-hard traditional Kremnoan swoon both before *and* since the announcement, but even then, he wasn’t prepared for this.

It must have been the battle high that made him do it. He won their competition by a single kill and every cell in his body completely released his inhibitions.

“So, when we get back,” the words had flown out of Phainon’s traitorous mouth, “do you want to take a bath together?”

Normally, he’s either ignored or outright told no. Sometimes he’d try to convince Mydei it was a good idea, a chance to bond, a nice way to unwind after a mission. Other times he’d leave it at that. A few times he’d just stand there and beg before being shut down entirely.

The last thing he expected was the soft grunt and annoyed “fine” he received.

Phainon attempts to calm himself down by wondering exactly *why* Mydei finally accepted his long standing invitation.

He supposes it’s the first time he’s asked since they started courting two months ago.

Maybe Mydei secretly enjoys being courted and he’s basking in the attention, Phainon thinks. The idea makes him chuckle to himself.

“What are you laughing at?”

The water around Phainon gently sloshes as he nearly jumps out of his seat. There he is: Mydeimos the Undying, Crown Prince of Kremnos and the very man whose heart Phainon is doing his utmost to win, in the flesh.

Or, more accurately, in the bathrobe. Barely.

The thing hangs off his waist, sleeves swinging by Mydei’s thighs until he steps into the water. A few mostly-healed bruises and minor scrapes litter his chest and arms. After that mission, he’s in slightly better shape than Phainon is, his only advantage being his insane body—

Insane *healing!*

Phainon rips his wide eyes away from Mydei, almost forgetting he has a question to answer. He prays his voice doesn’t shake too much. “The fact that I won by a single Titankin.”

“You’re still on that?” Mydei huffs, dropping onto the couch right next to Phainon, their shoulders brushing. “You’re such a sore winner.”

It’s both a blessing and a curse that Phainon wears his bathrobe like a normal person. He raises his hands placatingly. “I’m not allowed to have fleeting thoughts now? I promise I wasn’t dwelling on it.”

Water runs down his forearms and he swears he catches Mydei following it with his eyes. “Sure, Deliverer. I believe you.”

“Oh, you wound me.” Phainon pretends to swoon, one hand pressed to his forehead and the other over his heart. “Still calling me Deliverer after all we’ve been through?”

Mydei shrugs. “You haven’t complained about it until now.”

Phainon bites his lip and stares at the water ahead of him, debating whether he should come right out and say it. His pulse quickens with nervousness. “I never had a reason to, but things have changed between us, don’t you think?”

He doesn’t have to see it to know that Mydei’s thoughtful eyes are drilling holes into the side of his face. “You’re referring to the courting.”

An embarrassed flush creeps up Phainon’s neck. He plays with the string of his bathrobe underwater. “Well, mostly that. I mean, we *have* gotten closer, haven’t we? It even felt like we were more in sync than usual in battle today, and that’s saying something.”

The seconds drag on as he waits for Mydei to respond. Phainon grits his teeth, holds his breath, and pointedly stares at his knees. Mydei hasn’t stopped looking at him, much to his panic. Kephale knows what expression Mydei’s making as Phainon forces himself not to squirm.

“You say that,” Mydei drawls, “yet you've been acting like the opposite is true.”

Shock ripples through Phainon and he finally looks at Mydei properly. “What do you mean?”

Mydei leans back against the couch, crossing his arms. The action only brings his face a couple inches away from where it was and Phainon misses the proximity anyway. “You’re like those Okhemans who buy into the rumours about me: nervous for no reason, as if I’m about to bite your head off. I’m not, and you know it.”

So what's your problem? The question silently hangs between them.

Little does he know how embarrassing the answer would be to say out loud. Not that Phainon feels the need to hide from Mydei, but it sounds stupid even to himself.

Then again, Mydei wouldn't ask if he didn't care for the answer. Filling empty air with words isn't his style.

Clenching his fists on his lap, Phainon takes a breath. *It's just Mydei, it's just Mydei*, he repeats the words to himself like a mantra.

"I, uh… don't want to disappoint you." Phainon's entire face burns and he's positive that Mydei can see it. He pushes on. "If it wasn't obvious already, I've never courted anyone in any way before, much less a prince with an entire kingdom on his shoulders! Who wouldn't be nervous? It's not like I'm made of stone, after all."

"We've known each other for years," Mydei states, and there's a weight behind those words that Phainon is far too flustered to even begin to decipher.

"I know, it's just—" Phainon sighs at himself, shaking his head with a strained smile. "It's not you at all, just a lot of expectations."

Mydei snorts. "Expectations are nothing new to you, of all people. This is what makes you crack?"

Phainon straightens. "Don't worry, I'm not going to stop unless you want me to." He lets out a self-deprecating chuckle. "I'm sure you know how I am by now."

"Stuck in your own head like an idiot at all times." Mydei flicks his forehead, making him wince. "And don't forget: you moan about me calling you Deliverer, but you haven't called me anything different either. What's that saying you love so much? 'Be the change you want to see in the world'?"

“Oh? Is that special permission?” Phainon teases, his heart soaring. “Is it the first step in accepting my… advances?”

“All I’m saying is that you can’t complain when you’re the one who’s supposed to be taking action.”

A mischievous grin spreads across Phainon’s lips. “I shall take your words to heart, De.”

The immediate scowl he gets is worth the violent splash of water all over his face. “Not that.”

Phainon splutters a laugh as he swipes the water out of his eyes. “Why not? I’m taking initiative.”

“It wasn’t original. Unless you really want me to call you Snowy.”

“Oh, please.” Phainon scoops up water in both hands and slaps it directly into Mydei’s face.

Unfortunately, Mydei was about to say something and his mouth was open. Phainon realizes his mistake as Mydei angrily spits the water right back at him and he scrambles off the couch. Mydei chases after him.

“Don’t you run from me, Errand Boy!”

“Errand Boy?” Phainon squawks, sending a crashing wave at him. “That’s rich coming from you, Feral Cat.”

“Says the Eager Puppy himself.”

A weaker man would topple over from the torrent Mydei throws at Phainon’s side, but he’s far from weak. In his next move, Phainon dumps what must be an armful of water right on top of Mydei’s head.

“Alright, Sweet Tooth.”

They go back and forth, each name accompanied by a water attack.

“Fashion Failure.”

“Crystal Commander.”

“Double Antennae.”

“Bonfire Head.”

“What are you up to?”

Phainon startles at the new voice, which most definitely does not belong to Mydei. Caught off-guard, he yelps, loses his footing, and slips too quickly to recover from.

His whole world tips backwards and abruptly stops, suddenly filled by the spectacular view of a wet and disheveled Mydei. One firm, steady hand grips his wrist while the other holds his waist for balance. Those golden eyes meet Phainon’s before Mydei smirks and murmurs, “Clumsy Buffoon.”

Phainon can do nothing but blink stupidly at him.

Mydei smoothly looks away to greet the newcomer. “Castorice, we’re just ‘unwinding after a mission,’ in Sunshine here’s words. It was his idea.”

“I— what?” Did he hear that right? Did Mydei just call him… a pet name? Shaking his hair out of his face, Phainon straightens up. “Hold on, I’m not the one who started splashing. That was Prince Charming.”

Mydei’s hand drops from his waist as he snorts. “Way to throw me under the dromas. Who was it that escalated, again?”

“If I may,” Castorice interrupts, still two steps away from the water’s edge, “Lady Aglaea’s likely going to be here soon.” A small, amused smile appears. “I doubt she’d appreciate the commotion.”

Phainon laughs. “It’s a good thing you’re the one who caught us, then. Unless…” He trails off, looking around for a certain box. He spots it in its

usual place: under the table at the Tribios's favourite couch. "You secretly wanted to join us?"

Castorice follows his gaze and instantly knows what he's alluding to. The Tribios's box is stuffed full of bath toys, including water guns. Her eyes widen and she shakes her head. "Oh, no, I couldn't. There's no guarantee that I can maintain the proper distance…"

"Come on, Aglaea's getting closer by the second!" Phainon nudges Mydei's side with his elbow. "What do you say, Mydei?"

Mydei stares at Phainon, then looks to Castorice. "Do you know when she'll be here?"

"She mentioned an important meeting that should finish in a few minutes," Castorice muses, "but she also said she had a feeling it would go overtime."

Phainon grins. "You know what that means, right?"

It takes three whole seconds for the words to sink in. Mydei wastes no time in shoving Phainon and making a mad dash for the box.

"Augh!" Phainon wails, tripping over himself before wading after him. "Castorice, avenge me!"

Luckily for him, she's already moving. "On it."

~

Since the Tribios stopped teaching him, Phainon hasn't made a habit of visiting the archives. He's gone a couple times in the past few weeks, but even then, he couldn't find an extensive list of sources for the hottest topic on his mind: Kremnoan courting rituals.

This time, he strikes gold. A single tablet. He cradles it like a precious treasure and finds a nice corner to squeeze into so no one will notice exactly *how* Phainon's been navigating this… entire situation.

Once he’s sure no one is around to spy on him, he carefully slides his teleslate out of his pocket and checks his DMs on Spinner.

For the past two months, especially in the first week, he’s been receiving non stop messages from the Kremnoans. His DMs have always been open in case anyone needed help, not so he could receive it himself! He would never take their kindness for granted, so he dutifully read every single one, and it proved to be a *much* better source of information than the Okhema-centric archives. Any Kremnoan texts he finds here are few and far between, and it makes him wish he knew just where to look for what he needs so desperately.

He settles for the enthusiastic DMs from Mydei’s people, who clearly want only the best treatment for their Crown Prince. They shower him with seemingly endless traditions that he absolutely must follow or else he will never be forgiven, ever, even after he becomes a demigod, even by their children’s children’s children.

And he can’t blame them. He loves Mydei too.

Phainon nearly drops both his teleslate and the tablet and chokes on nothing. Yet the thought just feels so *right* when it crosses his mind. So comfortable, so correct, like it’s a simple truth of this world.

The sun never sets in Okhema, the gods bleed gold, and Phainon loves Mydei.

Turns out his half-joking declaration is serious business and his heart is in it much deeper than he thought. He couldn’t believe it *worked*, and here he is now, fretting over how to woo Mydei properly and in a way that he appreciates.

One good sign is that he hasn’t been rejected yet. If Mydei thought he was being stupid, wasn’t into him, or flat out considered him unworthy, he’d make it clear and say it more than once if Phainon was somehow confused the first time.

Maybe things can continue on like this for a few more months. He isn't sure how long the courting phase is supposed to last, but he won't complain if it means more dates with Mydei and having his full attention.

It's a hope worth clinging to.

He takes a calming breath and focuses on his research, comparing the tablet to the multiple messages that confirm its accuracy. The next step he wants to take seems easy enough. He can do it. He's Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, the Deliverer, a Chrysos Heir and hero of Amphoreus.

"Hello, Snowy."

Phainon's head whips to the side and he clutches both the tablet and teleslate to his chest. The only reason he doesn't make a peep is because his heart is in his throat.

When he sees who greeted him, he relaxes. "Ah, hello, Trinnon."

"Do you need help with anything?" Trinnon asks, tipping her head in curiosity. "You look super focused. A lot more than usual."

"No, I'm alright." Phainon smiles at her. "Just poking around. It's nice to see you, though. I should have guessed I'd find you here."

"Nice to see you too." Trinnon returns the smile. "It's almost the Parting Hour, so you should get home and rest. Especially after that hard mission you came back from."

Phainon nods. "I will."

Trinnon must be tired too, from her yawn and sleepy goodbye. When she walks away, Phainon sighs in relief. First Mydei in the baths, then Castorice, then Trinnon…

He sure is jumpy today.

Chapter End Notes

this MIGHT be the last chapter i get to post before 3.1 (depending on how fast I write) so i'll just say good luck on the tribbie pulls right now :D

also i'm going to deeply inhale the story when it comes out so chapter 4 or 5 or whatever comes right after 3.1 will take longer to be posted. i'm worried af about phainon by the way. i'm sure he'll be okay (coping)

Unorthodox Commission (Chartonus POV)

Chapter Notes

> guess who apparently lied to herself and said she couldn't finish another chapter before 3.1! maybe it's because i was having so much fun, maybe it's because i was excited to write this one, maybe it's both. i just hope i got chartonus's speech patterns right 😭
>
> enjoy!

Forging weapons comes naturally to him. Repairing them as well, though it doesn’t always take as long. Clanging hammers and spurting sparks are the sounds he hears most. They signify stability to him, a job well done, and the inherent joy of creation.

Right now, Chartonus takes an uncommon break from the forge to do some more delicate work.

A little girl and her mother had stopped by the other day, hearing about Chartonus’s talents. The girl wanted a toy. She’d lost her favourite wooden horse while running from the black tide, and her mother wanted to stop her tears. Recent arrivals in Okhema. He enjoys making toys, they’re quite cute, so he accepted without hesitation.

Hunkered down on a stool with a thin paintbrush in hand, Chartonus brings colour to the iron horse one steady stroke at a time.

Iron is stronger than wood, he’d told them. She won’t have to worry about it breaking if she drops it, even on the hardest cobblestones.

The paint won’t wash off, either. It’s waterproof, perfect for running around by the fountains. A few drops won’t ruin the finish. Accidents happen.

The horse would rust far too soon if it’s not kept dry at all times, though. Accidents should be fixed immediately.

When he finishes the mane, he sets the paintbrush in a cup of water and flexes his fingers. The tail is next. He also has the hooves, saddle, and face to do. He hopes to have it done by the third quint of the Action Hour so they can pick it up after their errands. He's well ahead of schedule. It's only the Lucid Hour.

He raises his head to give his eyes a break from the strain. As he stretches his neck and puts the horse on a crate, he spots an arm frantically waving at him.

"Chartonus!" Phainon calls, jogging to the forge.

He stands and waits for Phainon to reach him before nodding in greeting. "Hello, Phainon. Repair your sword, you request?"

"Not this time, my friend." Phainon wipes the sweat from his brow. The forge blazes hot as one of his colleagues gets to work on a shield. He's used to it, but Phainon isn't. "I actually have a commission. It's a bit… different from usual."

Chartonus nods again. If not sword repairs, it must be creating a new weapon altogether. He will do his best. "Listening, I am."

Phainon's face flushes and he picks at the ends of his sleeves. The forge is no hotter than usual. How strange that its heat is affecting him like this. "You know that thing on the end of Mydei's braid? The metal part that holds it together?"

He pictures Mydei in his mind's eye. Yes, he supposes he does know. "Hair cuff, you mean?"

With a big grin, Phainon snaps his fingers. "Yes! So that's what it's called," he muses. "I'd like for you to make one of those for him. As a gift. From me to him. Not from you." He sighs at himself and drags a hand down his face. "You know what I mean. I'm sure it's not the usual commission you get, but you're the best metalworker I know! Please? I only need one."

A gift for Mydei? Chartonus has vaguely heard about their relationship between the clangs of his hammer. He's more than happy to do this for Phainon. It must be an anniversary gift for his husband.

"Of course, Phainon. Honoured to help, I would be."

Phainon lets out a sigh like he's been relieved of a great burden. "Thank you *so* much. You're a real lifesaver." He pauses, then holds up a single finger. "One more thing, actually. I also need a Steelclaw Dagger. I have to slay a lion with it and present its pelt to Mydei by the end of next week."

Chartonus blinks at him, though the other can't see it. Some kind of new competition they're having? A new hobby they're taking up?

Phainon frowns, bringing a hand to his chin as he thinks. "It's as close as I can get to tradition since the actual Steelclaw Beasts aren't around anymore. Then again, maybe it's better this way… because of what I've heard about Kremnos's history and its first king and all that."

Traditions that don't involve forging aren't in Chartonus's scope of knowledge. It must involve killing a Steelclaw Beast, whatever it's for.

He does know about the first king, though. The lion story is integral to the foundation of Kremnos. Didn't Mydei's mother kill a lion too? With her bare hands, no less. Maybe he should tell Phainon, but such a feat wouldn't be so incredible if it were tradition. The suggestion may miss the mark. Phainon clearly wants to adhere to something.

"Lion, you kill. Rule Kremnos, you wish to?" They can't even find Castrum Kremnos, but why else follow in the footsteps of royalty?

Phainon's eyebrows fly up. "Hm? Oh goodness, no. It's a way to show my dedication to Mydei. It might seem more impressive if I killed a Steelclaw Beast without using a shield as they've done in the past, but the lion holds more significance, I think. And the Steelclaw Beast is still somewhat involved if I use the dagger, right? … Technically?"

“In name,” Chartonus says. “Extinct, real beast is. Claws and bones, cannot use. Long eroded, they are.”

“Exactly.” Phainon nods sagely. “So, one hair cuff and one Steelclaw Dagger. How does that sound?”

“Good. This project, I prioritize. One thing, I finish first.”

“That’s no problem at all.” Phainon digs a folded sheet out of his pocket. “By the way, I do have a design in mind for the hair cuff. I don’t mind waiting around until you finish your current thing.” He peers around Chartonus and spots the horse. “You can let me know when you’re done. I’ll do some shopping in the meantime, then we can talk.”

Chartonus nods. “Send for you, I will, if see you, I do not. Thank you, Phainon.”

~

It’s a blessing from the Titans that the sketch Phainon brings to him actually looks pretty nice.

It feels like it was just yesterday when Chartonus unceremoniously threw Phainon’s best attempt at an outfit into the furnace. It simply didn’t look good. He didn’t want to subject those poor clothes to future mishaps. Phainon must have gotten help this time.

The hair cuff design doesn’t need any modifications, thank goodness. He has all the materials he needs on hand, jewels included.

Throughout the process of making both the hair cuff and the dagger, Phainon stops by every day to check in. Chartonus knows he means well, he’s not being overbearing or making changes at every step, he’s just eager about this very special gift and wants to see how it’s coming along. Phainon has the courtesy to refrain from trying to chat while he’s actively working, so he hardly minds.

The hair cuff is finished first. Chartonus prefers to do the more intricate parts of an order before the simple ones. He stores it in the fanciest box he has, tucked away in a safe place to minimize the chances of it being lost or stolen. Phainon's utter delight when he's told Chartonus should be completely done the order in one more day seems to light up the entire forge.

Chartonus finishes the dagger right on schedule. He's made countless identical daggers over the years, so as enjoyable as it always is to craft something original, it's equally nice to go through the motions of the usual routine. The execution is flawless. Practiced, as it should be.

He sets the box on top of a crate and rearranges it so the hair cuff and dagger can sit inside without scratching the other. Phainon should be here any moment now.

Chartonus turns around and— ah, there he is.

Phainon's hand is halfway raised to wave and his mouth open to call out, then he visibly pauses. A laugh bubbles out of him instead. "I see we're both ready."

With a nod, Chartonus brings the box to him. "To your liking, I hope it is."

The moment it's in Phainon's hands, he marvels at it and gently opens it. He gasps. "It's… it's perfect. Both of them. I… hardly have the words."

The way his eyes are glued to the hair cuff makes Chartonus's heart swell with pride. It's made of the same metal as Mydei's current one, but has small lion engravings and blue jewels alternating all around it, forming a diamond pattern. The colours should match Mydei's necklace seamlessly.

Seeing it in progress is much different from seeing the finished product. Chartonus is glad it meets, even exceeds, his expectations.

Phainon closes the box and gives Chartonus a warm smile. "I can't thank you enough, truly. I can try, though." He slips a hand into his pocket and takes out a sizable coin pouch, offering it to Chartonus.

“Full payment, you already gave me.”

“This is a tip! Something extra for your hard work. I know I’m a guaranteed repeat customer, but this means a lot to me. Please, take it.” Phainon thrusts the bag forward, insisting.

Fair enough. Chartonus accepts it. “Grateful, I am. On your hunt, good luck.”

Phainon grins and clutches the box to his chest. “Thank you, my friend.” With a final wave, he begins to walk away.

Before he can forget and Phainon can get too far, Chartonus says, “Happy anniversary.”

Phainon looks over his shoulder, confused. “Happy what?” He nearly bumps into someone, swiftly apologizes, and turns back just long enough to say, “Have a good day!”

And he’s gone.

Chartonus isn’t sure if that was some kind of delayed reaction or Phainon didn’t actually hear him. He doesn’t dwell on it. Whether Phainon heard or not, he wishes them all the best.

He returns to work and picks up his hammer.

~

Several days later, Mydei pops up at the forge, cracked and dented gauntlets in hand. A mundane sight, if not for the newest addition to his outfit.

The hair cuff Chartonus made glimmers in the sunlight before it dims under the shade. It suits him better than expected.

“I wanted to get here before Phainon,” Mydei says as a greeting, “because there’s something I’d like to ask.”

So Phainon’s coming soon with a sword repair. He’ll be on the lookout. “Yes?”

Mydei carefully pinches the end of his braid and lifts it. “You made this, right?”

Chartonus nods. “I did. Proud creation, it is.”

The corner of Mydei’s lips quirks up. “It should be. I have to thank you for making it. That said, the Deliverer forgot one thing. I’m going to need multiples of it, just in case. I’d like you to make three more identical ones, along with fixing my gauntlets. Is that alright with you?”

In moments like these, Chartonus is glad he keeps the sketches and designs of everything he makes. “Of course, Mydei.”

“Thank you.” Mydei glances over his shoulder and curses under his breath. When Chartonus looks past him, he spots Phainon making his way over. “Don’t tell him about this, by the way.”

Chartonus doesn’t see why not, but he agrees anyway. He’s just happy they both like the gift and, evidently, had a good anniversary.

No Box Unticked (Castorice POV)

Chapter Notes

> so... 3.1 huh. it both healed me (mydei and phainon are okay) and destroyed me (i have to wait 3 weeks to get mydei and queen gorgo will never be playable). and now everything i've written for phaidei is hitting DIFFERENT after doing the new story quests, especially the chartonus chapter which i did not expect at all
>
> i love castorice so much that i actually wrote most of this before 3.1 dropped but i told myself to WAIT before i got something wildly wrong that would be disproven within hours lmao
>
> enjoy!

Castorice drags the damp cloth along the gravestone, softly humming along to the instrumental music playing through her earbuds. Despite the exceedingly late hour, it’s just as bright in the cemetery as it is while all of Okhema is up and about.

It’s the best time to come and clean up. There’s less risk of running into someone visiting their deceased loved ones this way. In fact, no one has ever stopped by during the Curtain-Fall Hour. Certainly not while she was here.

It’s just her, her music, the dust, her cloth, her bucket, and the graves of people she’s embalmed.

Each clean gravestone is an achievement. Proof that she can help the living without needing to be physically close to them. She takes care of their loved ones and allows them to rest in peace, and that comfort lets the living continue their own lives without worry.

Of course, there are the superstitious and those who worry regardless. She tries not to dwell on that.

As she reaches the end of the second row, she's gone from humming to wordlessly singing under her breath. By the middle of the third row, her head sways from left to right.

Her eyelids are about to fall halfway when she thinks she senses a shift in the air. Must be the slight breeze blowing by.

"Castorice," someone's voice booms from the entrance.

She silently jumps out of her skin and whirls around, plucking out her earbuds. The man approaching her is none other than Mydei.

Her eyes grow even wider. She thought he tended to sleep at this hour. He always insists that people fight at their best after proper rest. Why would he be awake?

Why would he be at a *cemetery?*

Castorice scrambles to her feet, leaving her cloth on top of the gravestone. "Good morning, Lord Mydei," she says as he stops at the appropriate distance in front of her. "You're not here for the Eurypon Mound, are you?"

It's a ways from the rows of plots, but some time after Mydei brought the Kremnoan detachment to Okhema, a small group of them threw together a mound of dirt and stuck a metal rod in it. She noticed that every year, on both Eurypon's and Mydei's birthdays, some Kremnoans would go to the mound and take turns spitting on it.

A few times, she's had the pleasure of cleaning gravestones while they were here. She believes she's properly learned a Kremnoan curse word or two from them.

Mydei has never been among their number, to her knowledge. That doesn't mean he can't start. She wouldn't blame him. The look of "where did that come from?" on his face tells her otherwise.

He shakes his head. "No, I'm not. I've been looking for you."

Castorice blinks, unsure of what he could possibly need at this hour. From her, no less. It must be serious if it's keeping him from sleeping. "Is something the matter?"

Mydei crosses his arms and stares past her, his frown deepening. He must really not want to share, yet here he is, psyching himself up. When his eyes lock onto hers, his uncertainties are swimming in them. "You haven't told the Deliverer about any Kremnoan courtship customs, have you?"

She's read about them, sure, but she hasn't told a soul. Phainon hasn't asked her a single question on the subject. He doesn't need to… does he?

"I have not."

"Then who is—?" Mydei sighs, pinching the bridge of his nose and squeezing his eyes shut. "Unbelievable," he mutters to himself.

Now they're both frowning, though Castorice is more puzzled than anguished. "May I ask what's bothering you? We can sit down, if you want." Preferably on the grass. A bench would put them too close.

Mydei raises his head like he's succumbed to his fate, staring blankly at the sky. "Yeah. I need to sit down."

With a sympathetic nod, she leads him away from the plots and sits neatly on the ground. Mydei sits two paces closer to Castorice than she'd allow anyone else to, his face finally relaxing somewhat. Her worry spikes. He only does that when he's *really* in trouble, and she can count those instances on one hand.

She gasps as Mydei flops down on his back, arms spread. "Lord Mydei?"

"I don't understand." He weakly glares at the bright blue sky, utterly defeated. "This should never have happened."

Castorice has to restrain herself from leaning closer. "Did something happen between you and Lord Phainon?"

“Yes. Everything is happening between us.” His claws dig into the grass, ripping a few blades from the dirt. “Nothing… should be.”

As far as she knows, “everything” has always happened between them. Sparring, picking fights, the way one looks at the other when they think no one is watching, sneakily buying gifts for each other during holidays. Phainon even came to her for advice on designing the very hair cuff Mydei’s wearing. She can’t imagine how that would take on a different shape now, unless they’re running into massive problems that neither of them knows how to solve. Even then, if they have a big argument, they just spar and whatever happens in the ring is enough for them to be alright afterwards.

That’s normal for them. What is Mydei so confused about?

“Forgive me,” Castorice says, “but I’m not sure what you mean.”

Mydei sighs again, shorter but no less frustrated. “Do you remember when the Deliverer decided to prank me and formally declare his intention to court me in the middle of the market?”

Only years of masking her own emotions could prepare her for the need to completely conceal her shock. If Mydei so much as raises his head, she needs to be sure he won’t see the illusion shattering before her very eyes.

He continues, “Well, he’s ticking all the boxes. According to tradition, he’s performed flawlessly. I don’t know if it’s dumb luck, his nature, or if… this courtship thing is growing on me,” Mydei says that last part through gritted teeth and firmly plants a hand over his face. “I nearly called him Phainon in front of him the other day. I never do that. I have *never* done that. I have spent hours thinking about why I would do that, and all the conclusions I come to make absolutely no sense.

“He didn’t even mean it. I do not see why he’s going so far to mess with me. But of course he would, he’s the flawless Deliverer and the most sincere person on Amphoreus, he just has to see things through to the end. He’d twist himself in every direction to keep some stupid promise. That’s

just who he is. This is insane, Castorice. I cannot begin to tell you what his problem is. He is beyond my comprehension."

As he falls silent and visibly tries to decipher the turmoil in his heart, Castorice is left reeling. They are on *wildly* different pages.

She isn't one to buy into rumours, but so long as they aren't baseless or they're entertaining, she'll at least acknowledge them.

She's seen the video. She's skimmed a few comments. She's heard people talk. She's been friends with them both for years. She's watched them interact day in, day out, both in times of peace and in battle.

When people started speculating that they've been romantically involved for a long time and were just now going public with it, what else was she going to think? It made enough sense for them to get married in secret. Sure, she's been a little sad that she, the Tribios, and maybe even Hyacine weren't invited as witnesses, but Aglaea obviously officiated. She's the demigod of Romance. At least one of them was there.

But apparently they were never together. The moment they started courting was recorded for all of Okhema to see. And Mydei came to find her while the city sleeps because he's… enjoying it?

Mydei had better buy her breakfast if he's going to put her through this.

She has a nagging feeling that if she tells him she doubts it's a prank, he either won't believe her or he'll be sent into an even bigger tailspin. Castorice clears her throat, blinking the despair out of her eyes. "What are these conclusions, if you don't mind me asking?"

"Nothing good," Mydei grumbles, "and nothing productive."

"They must mean something if they're keeping you awake."

"Not every thought is worth considering."

"Yet you're considering them."

“I’m dismissing them.”

“To me,” Castorice corrects, “but not to yourself.”

The almost petulant downturn of his lips tells her she’s won. His hand slides off his face. “This is not a fair fight. You have a proximity advantage.”

Castorice smiles. “You’re the one who put yourself within Deathbed Confession distance. I sat down first.”

Mydei groans, turning his face away. “So what?”

“So, I think you should tell me what your conclusions are. You will feel better, Lord Mydei. I won’t tell anyone.”

Seconds pass, and as they morph into minutes, Castorice shifts into a more comfortable position, leans back on her hands, and tips her face towards the sky. She already knows what he’s going to say— rather, what he wants to say but likely won’t admit to. But she’s more than willing to patiently wait until he says anything at all.

His breathing slows a bit, a side effect of being so close for so long. If they stay like this, he’ll eventually melt into a half-asleep puddle that won’t actually doze off. After the ordeal Mydei’s putting himself through, she plans to let him sleep here while she returns to her cleaning. Just for a little bit.

“I’m falling for it,” Mydei says, almost too soft to hear. “The prank… the courting. It’s working. Stupid.”

Castorice hums. “I don’t think your feelings are stupid.”

Mydei’s face rolls around to face her, unimpressed. “What would you do in my place?”

As far as she knows, not one soul has been brave enough to have more than a passing interest in her when it comes to courtship. If someone was in love with her, they never said anything. Besides, it’s something she’s long

understood that she'll never have so long as she's cursed. All the books and her observations tell her how important physical touch is.

Still, she imagines: a dear friend asked to court her, she accepted, and along the journey, she found herself in love. The answer is obvious to her, but that may be because of who she is as a person. If she allowed herself to fall so deeply, this person must be worth risking her heart, and they should know right away. Even if they could never touch, even if they were doomed to three paces' distance.

Either that, or she would keep it to herself because there may be no point in saying anything. She supposes it depends on the friend. She doesn't see that path lasting long before it turns into the first course of action, though.

"I'm not sure," Castorice muses. "It would be nice to be courted, I think. I'm afraid I have no personal experience on the matter. However… I believe I would respond the way my heart tells me to. If only because I was in your position, I would have it in me to hope for a good outcome. Even slightly."

Mydei's eyes narrow. "And what is this good outcome?"

Castorice giggles behind her hand. "A lasting relationship, of course."

Mydei faces the sky, eyelashes fluttering. "Why did I even ask?" he mumbles.

"Because you're tired." Castorice pushes to her feet and takes a single step away. He looks no less exhausted. "You should get some rest while you still can. It will be the Entry Hour before we know it."

"Too far." Mydei's eyes slip closed. "I'll just sleep here."

Castorice takes another step back, then another, then turns around to return to the gravestones. "As long as you're comfortable," she says over her shoulder. "Let's hope your back doesn't hurt tomorrow."

"I've been through worse," comes Mydei's wispy response.

After she picks up her cloth and starts dusting again, she glances in his direction every so often to check on him. She dusts three more rows and he doesn’t so much as stir.

If those two managed to fool not only her but all of Okhema, it must mean that whatever’s going on between them is mutual. She wonders if Mydei will lose his mind again when he inevitably finds out. Her metaphorical door is open if he needs to talk.

She’s more than happy to nudge him in the right direction. They deserve each other.

Garden of... Love? (Tribios POV)

Chapter Notes

> why on earth did i designate chapter 6 as the tribios chapter and then proceed to play 3.1 😭😭😭 after seeing that backstory, all three of them deserve the most wonderful things
>
> enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“A little more to the left,” Phainon instructs, flapping his hands in that direction.

Tribbie and Trinnon glide to the left, each holding opposite sides of a wide picnic blanket. “Is here good, Snowy?” Tribbie asks.

Phainon squints, loudly humming in consideration. His hands slide to the right. “A bit more that way.”

As they shift the blanket over, Trianne huffs impatiently. She floats by his shoulder with a picnic basket. “How much longer until I can put this down? It’s *heavy.”*

“Just a few more seconds,” Phainon assures, wiggling his hands to signal *go back.* Once the blanket is perfectly lined up in the middle of the blue marble circle, he grins. “Okay, perfect!”

Trianne lets out a loud sigh of relief, blowing her bangs out of her eyes, and zooms to the blanket. “Finally!”

“Not too hard or the dessert will deflate,” Phainon rushes to warn her, a hand outstretched.

Tribbie and Trinnon gently set the blanket down. Trianne places the basket with careful precision. The moment everything is in place, the three of them

cheer and high-five.

Phainon laughs warmly. “Thank you, Lady Tribbie, Lady Trianne, and Lady Trinnon.”

“You’re welcome,” they say in unison.

“But why do you want to sit over here and not on the grass?” Tribbie asks as Trinnon busies herself with smoothing out the blanket’s wrinkles.

“Yeah,” Trianne agrees, nose scrunched. “You’ll get numb from sitting on a rock for so long.”

“It’s not that bad.” Phainon smiles. “This is a more secluded spot. We can’t sit around and impede research, now can we? All these scholars might trip over us.”

He does have a point. The Garden of Life is as busy as it normally is in the afternoon, and it was tricky enough to get all the nosy people out of their business. Thankfully, the sort of people who are into research are also the sort to focus on the task at hand, which is decidedly *not* finding out why Phainon is preparing a picnic.

Trianne bursts into a fit of giggles. “As if either of you could be tripped over! You stick out like sore thumbs.”

“Some people don’t pay attention,” Trinnon points out.

“And accidents happen,” Tribbie adds.

“By the way, Snowy.” Trinnon looks up from the blanket. “Do you want **us** to scatter flower petals too? Not where you’re sitting, but around the blanket.”

Phainon’s eyes widen. “Oh,” he breathes, “not a bad idea.”

Tribbie gasps. “Which flowers? Quick, so one of **us** can rush to the market and grab them before De gets here!”

“Gah, I don’t know, I’m being put on the spot here…” Phainon’s hand runs through his hair as he frowns deeply, thinking hard. “A romantic flower, I think? Ah, but it should follow some sort of Kremnoan custom, shouldn’t it? I don’t want to mess something up by accident—”

“Hey!” Trianne darts up and gives him a sharp poke to the forehead. “Quit worrying so much. De will like anything you put here, **we** can feel it.” She grins and crosses her arms. “This picnic isn’t some custom anyway. Right?”

“It isn’t,” Phainon says, shifting nervously. “But I still want it to be good for him. No, more than good— it needs to be perfect.”

“You’re doing this to show him how much you want to be with him!” Tribbie flies in circles around his head before stopping next to Trianne, smiling sweetly with her hands clasped beneath her chin. “Isn’t that more than enough?”

“ **We** think it’s a sincere gesture of devotion,” Trinnon pipes up, drifting over to join them. “If you can’t decide, then red roses would be a good choice. They’re associated with romance and they match De’s style.”

“Because they’re both red!” Trianne cheers, nodding sagely. “And it’ll really set the stage. Don’t you think, Snowy?”

She and Tribbie watch intently as Phainon considers it. When he finally nods, all three of them beam, hold hands, and spin together with a loud “Hooray!”

Trinnon breaks from the circle first. “I’ll go get the roses. Be back soon.”

“Wait,” Phainon blurts, digging through his pockets. “Balance Coins, Balance Coins… There we go.” He takes out his coin purse and grabs a handful of them, then presents them to Trinnon. “Will this be enough?”

Trinnon takes the coins, careful not to drop them. “Even if it isn’t, **we** don’t mind covering the rest.”

“Please, you three have done so much for me over the years.” Phainon rests his hand over his heart. “I’ll pay you back if it isn’t enough. It’s the least I can do.”

“ **We** have an idea!” Tribbie raises her hand. “Tell **us** how it goes and **we’ll** call it even.”

“As long as you’re sure.” Phainon smiles, then turns to Trinnon. “Thank you again.”

“You’re welcome.” Trinnon gives him a single pat on the head. “I’ll be back as soon as I can.” With that, she flies away.

Trianne gestures somewhere behind her. “And I’ll go fetch the chimeras. I’ll pick the cutest, cuddliest ones for you two. They won’t eat the food, I promise.”

Phainon hums. “Do chimeras eat human food?”

“If they’re hungry enough.” Trianne shrugs. “Sometimes I bring them treats, but those are special occasions. Also, how many chimeras should I bring? One each?”

“That would be best.”

“Alrighty. I have just the ones in mind.” With a self-assured nod, Trianne zips away.

Tribbie lands on the ground and walks towards the blanket to inspect it. She *would* start taking the food out and arranging it, but it would be better to leave it in the basket so it can stay warm for longer. When she lifts her head, she’s greeted by the giant form of Kephale themself.

It’s cute that Phainon noticed Mydei’s tendency to find hidden spots that overlook this specific view. Or maybe it’s something both of them share and neither of them noticed. She’s caught Phainon loitering in Kephale Plaza plenty of times. As silly as the two of them can be when they’re together, they really are two peas in a pod.

When she turns back to Phainon, he's nervously checking their surroundings and sneaking glances at his teleslate. The sight makes Tribbie smile.

"He's going to love it," she assures, resting a hand on his leg. "You have nothing to worry about, **we** promise."

"Thank you." Phainon sighs, scrubbing at his cheek. "I apologize, but I just can't help it. He sent me a message a minute ago saying he's on his way. From where, I'm not sure."

"Did you ask?"

"If I did, he'd tell me to be patient." Phainon chuckles, shaking his head at himself. "Wouldn't be the first time."

"At least **we're** pretty sure he isn't coming from the baths," Tribbie says. "He walks so fast that if he was, he might get here before we'd be ready."

"You make a good point, Lady Tribbie." Phainon pauses, peeks at his teleslate again, then asks, "Do you think he'll like the food? I ordered it straight from Pherusa."

She perks up, clapping her hands once. "That's the best person you could order from! All of us Chrysos Heirs can vouch for her cooking." She taps her chin with a fingertip. "Although… De doesn't get to eat her food often, does he? Since she cooks when he's not available to. Missions and expeditions and all. It might be even more of a treat to him."

"And she knows all the traditional Kremnoan dishes," Phainon adds. "By heart, no less."

"Exactly. Every time they cooked for us together, they were unstoppable, too." Tribbie giggles. "We should find excuses to have feasts more often."

Phainon sighs dreamily. "Yes, please. I swear the food tastes better when it's the two of them in the kitchen. And there's more of it."

“Whose birthday is next?” Tribbie muses, eyes narrowed. “Oh, it’s Agy’s! Let’s both ask her to request a whole lot of food. Especially extra dessert. Then we can all have the leftovers for days and days.”

“We should, huh? If we’re going to do that, who should ask first, and who should deal the critical hit? The second person should absolutely be able to make her accept.”

“Good question… she’s known **us** for longer, but hardly anyone says no to you, Snowy.”

“I can’t imagine anyone telling you no either.”

“But which of us is she less likely to want to negotiate with?”

“I’m… not sure.” Phainon deflates. “She negotiates with everyone.”

“In that case, maybe it doesn’t matter which of us goes first. As long as we have a solid plan—”

Tribbie pauses, eyes wide. Her vision gives way to the Marmoreal Market, faded to white at the edges, and a familiar face. She gasps and her hands fly to her mouth.

“What is it, Lady Tribbie?” Phainon reaches for a greatsword he left at home, alarmed. “What’s wrong?”

“It’s Trinnon.” Her hands press to her cheeks as she bounces on the balls of her feet, unsure of what to do. “Oh no… She’s run into De!”

~

“Are you sure nothing’s wrong?” Mydei tries to see what Trinnon’s hiding behind her back, but she won’t let him. She rotates midair just enough to hide the bouquet of roses from him.

“Yes, I’m sure.” Trinnon nods hastily. “Everything is alright.”

“Then why do you look like you’re in trouble?” Mydei crosses his arms, glancing around suspiciously. “Who is following you?”

“Nobody, **we** promise.” Trinnon shakes her head with just as much vigour. “**We’re** just in a bit of a rush and didn’t expect to run into you, that’s all.”

“Oh. I see.” Mydei relaxes, then shrugs. “If you’re delivering mail and need help, don’t hesitate to ask me for it. Whatever you’re carrying must be heavy. I can make time.”

Trinnon panics. Does she really seem so strained that he thinks she’s holding a weighty package? All she’s carrying are Phainon’s hopes and expectations for a romantic picnic with the very man in front of her. She can do this. She can slip away.

“That’s very sweet of you, De, but it’ll be okay.” Trinnon gives him her best, least nervous smile. “This person just needs their delivery urgently. **We’re** a bit worried about them, that’s all.”

Mydei’s eyes widen and he nods. “My apologies, Lady Tribios. Don’t let me keep you. Good luck.”

“Thank you very much.” Trinnon carefully angles herself so he can’t see the roses as she flies away. Once she turns a corner, looks back, and doesn’t see him anymore, she sighs with relief.

She stays well above people’s heads for the rest of the trip, taking an alternate route so she doesn’t run into Mydei again. When she approaches the Garden of Life, her vision changes, fading to black at the edges, the telltale sign for Trianne’s perspective.

There’s a light blue and white chimera squirming in her arms and a red and orange one nearby. Right next to that chimera is a pair of familiar armoured legs.

She blinks and finds Tribbie and Phainon in front of her, the former frowning with her head in her hands.

“You saw that too, right, Tribbie?” Trinnon asks.

“Yes.” Tribbie raises her head, then faces a worried Phainon. “Now Trianne’s run into De.”

~

“ **We’re** so sorry!” Trianne scrambles to gently pry the chimera off of Mydei’s leg.

The little guy holds tight to Mydei’s pants, yelling and climbing higher. Its claws softly scrape against the armour. Soon, it climbs nearly out of her reach, and she’s having a hard enough time with the energetic chimera already in her arms.

“Gah, cookie crumbs,” Trianne mutters, stretching higher. The red and orange one, which she’s dubbed Kremmy, jumps and clings onto the fabric at Mydei’s waist. “No,” she whines. “Bad Kremmy!”

“Kremmy?” Mydei scoops the poor chimera into his hands before it can fall. He looks between Kremmy and the other chimera, Elizzy. “Are these two slacking off?”

“Oh, no, definitely not.” Trianne tucks Elizzy into the crook of her elbow and makes a grabby hand for Kremmy. “A couple of researchers were looking for these guys in particular. **We** knew exactly where they’d be, and **we** were right! Except Kremmy seems to like you. A lot.”

Sure enough, Kremmy has already made its home in Mydei’s palms, curling up without a care in the world. She swears it starts purring.

“You’re heading to the Garden of Life, then?” Mydei asks.

This is the absolute worst case scenario. The chimeras are supposed to be there *before* Mydei shows up. Whether it’s to help Phainon destress a little beforehand or simply because of the cute image they give, they cannot appear at the same time as Mydei under any circumstance.

Phainon's going to be so disappointed. She had one job, and it was foiled by betrayal. All those pets and belly rubs, and this is how Kremmy repays her. Unbelievable!

"Once Kremmy finally agrees to go with **us** ." Trianne pouts at it.

"I'm headed there too. I can take this one with me and make your job easier." Mydei points at Elizzy, who's still wiggling incessantly. "You seem to have your hands full."

Trianne… can't deny that. It takes enough energy to keep Elizzy from leaping out of her grasp entirely. What's got it so excited this time?

She relents with a sigh, both hoping Phainon will forgive her and knowing that he would. "Alright. You can come. Thanks, De."

"You're welcome." Mydei's already turned away and started walking.

The moment Trianne catches up, Kremmy decides to crawl up Mydei's arm and sprawl out on his shoulder, howling in victory with its tail swishing. Kremmy's lucky it's so cute, or Trianne would be a lot more upset at this change of plan.

Sorry, everyone, Trianne laments in the Tribios mind link.

It's okay, Trinnon's voice echoes, ***we've*** *already told Snowy.*

And he doesn't think it's a total disaster! comes Tribbie's voice. *Good work, team.*

Well, if they can all consider this a job well done, Trianne certainly won't complain.

~

When an up and coming teleslate game developer kindly, humbly asked Tribbie to test her game called "Rocket Racers," saying it was inspired by the Tribios themselves, what else was she supposed to say other than a resounding "yes"?

That was four days ago, and now that Tribbie finally has time, she finds a nice gazebo, pops in her earbuds, and opens the app. Teleslate vibration is on and the volume is as loud as she can stand for prolonged periods. She wants the *full* experience.

At the course selection menu, the upbeat music is cut off by her text tone and multiple banner notifications in rapid succession.

Phainon: Thanks again for your help yesterday!

Phainon: It was perfect!

Phainon: I owe all three of you

Phainon: But I can’t believe this article was written so quickly…

Okay, she can spare a few minutes to check their messages.

She puts her bubbling excitement on hold to take a look at the link Phainon sent her. She’s instantly greeted by one of the most adorable pictures she’s seen in a very long time.

It’s taken from behind a bush and the angle isn’t perfect, but the image is clear as day. Mydei’s in the middle of saying something, facing away from Phainon, while petting a happy Elizzy in his lap. Kremmy has its paws on his other knee, looking up at him with begging eyes.

And though Mydei is the most obvious focus, Tribbie doesn’t miss how impossibly smitten Phainon looks, gazing at Mydei as if one smile from him would make all his fears disappear for eternity.

“Aww,” Tribbie coos softly to herself, scrolling down to the text.

As she skims it, it becomes obvious that it was written in a rush. Not surprising since it was posted yesterday evening, mere hours after their picnic. Strangely enough, the author is gobsmacked about Mydei having a soft, gentle side and not “showing the chimera who’s boss with a true lion’s roar.” Maybe it’s because she’s known him for so long, but it doesn’t *feel* like a secret.

Then again, this is Okhema, the land of rumours and gossip. Tribbie sighs and closes the article.

If this person is shocked at how Mydei treats chimeras, they could never handle seeing how he treats the gifts Phainon’s given him.

Chapter End Notes

> tribios solos in mario kart btw i don't make the rules. you can't tell me that having rainbow road in that trailer wasn't a sign

Her Heartfelt Wish (Pherusa POV)

Chapter Notes

> phew, just in time for 3.2 to drop in a couple days 😭 i had to rework this chapter like. twice. simply because hoyo said mydei cooks for the chrysos heirs a lot. looked at my "chrysos heir head chef" chapter title and screamed in agony
>
> also yes the chapter count did increase. yes i know that's a lot more chapters. it will likely happen again as i figure out more things and we get more characters and their lore. it was only a matter of time...

Pherusa’s knife glides through the strawberries, effortlessly slicing them to the perfect size for a fruit salad. Behind her, the whisk knocks against the bowl as Mydei mixes the honeycake batter. They don’t normally talk beyond what’s necessary while in the kitchen together, both preferring to focus on cooking. It’s nice, she thinks, having helpful company that doesn’t chat her ear off every single time.

It’s even more nice when it’s the crown prince himself. She truly considers herself lucky, and she’s especially proud of how far he’s come. To think he used to try cracking eggs in the batter instead of using a flat surface. The memory of his first attempt makes her chuckle to this day.

He seems distracted this morning, though.

When checking the batter for eggshells, he stared a bit too deeply. While they discussed which fruits to put in the salad, he said blueberries twice. Even now, the whisk either moves too slow or too fast, the speed changing at odd intervals.

He’s not mulling over how to subtly mess up Phainon’s food again, is he? If he’s thinking this hard, he must be either running out of ideas or getting rusty. That’s not the Prince Mydeimos she knows. He should be quicker on his feet than this.

Sure, she'll usually salvage one of the sides on Phainon's plate, but she does look forward to Mydei's creativity in the kitchen. It's not fun if he starts losing his touch.

Pherusa glances at him over her shoulder, eyes narrowed. He's tense. "Mydeimos," she calls, noting the barest hint of a flinch from him. "I know something's on your mind."

He pauses, then sighs. "It's fine," he mumbles, stirring with newfound vigour. "I've got it under control."

That may technically be true, but she can still read him any day of the week.

"Care to share your latest endeavours?" She leans her hip against the counter. When he hesitates, she prods, "Is it about your Deliverer?"

"My—?" He splutters, whirling around to face her. Flushed cheeks, furrowed eyebrows, refusal to meet her eyes… She got him. Mydei groans.

Pherusa, on the other hand, is the picture of smugness. She throws her head back and laughs. "Come now, Mydeimos. It's about time you gave him an answer, isn't it? It's been long enough."

Six months, to be exact. Courtship tends to take longer for royalty, but considering the lack of parents *and* kingdom involved, many steps can be easily skipped. No extensive talks about royal duties, no lands or people to be assimilated if Phainon were also royalty, no travelling long distances for either of them. They don't need approval from the officials in court or anyone else for that matter, considering they're both Chrysos Heirs, which is a first in Kremnoan history. It's difficult to question the worthiness of an almost-demigod, especially one as universally trusted as Phainon.

It's just the two of them.

Well, the two of them and the countless Kremnoans coaching Phainon in secret. Pherusa is one of them: she told him about weaving a wreath of myrtles to place around Mydei's neck, both blessing their relationship and

calling forth endless victories in the battles ahead. It's a step that typically takes place later in the process, and often a sign of impending proposal.

She sent that DM three weeks ago and got an enthusiastic "Thank you!!!" with five smiley faces in response. Has Phainon gone through with it already?

"I will." Mydei's face twists into a grimace. "That's… what I've been thinking about, truth be told."

Pherusa's eyebrows nearly leap off her face. She didn't expect to be *this* right. "Oh?"

He half turns away to absentmindedly scrape the sides of the bowl, something between longing and nervousness in his eyes. "I'd like to place an order for dinner three nights from now." He purses his lips like it's a pain to say the words aloud. "I would make it myself, but that's when we return from a mission. I won't have the energy."

"You certainly won't." Pherusa crosses her arms. "I won't have you dragging your injured self through my kitchen anyhow. So, what would you like?"

Mydei reaches for his pocket, freezes, moves his hand away, thinks better of it, then keeps going. He pulls out a big sticky note and wordlessly hands it to her. Not bothering to check her reaction, or perhaps too embarrassed to risk a glance, he shuffles to where they keep the pans.

Based on *that* odd spectacle, she can't say she's surprised by what's written on the paper.

Before Phainon practically confessed his love in public, Mydei rarely placed orders at all. He either cooked on his own, to eat by himself in his chambers, or with her to eat with the other Chrysos Heirs. When he returned from missions, he'd just sleep off whatever injuries he had and wake up good as new before continuing on with his day, depending on the hour.

Now, he makes sure Phainon’s favourite foods are brought to Mydei’s chambers once a week along with Mydei’s typical dinner. He still helps her make it all, when he can. She repays him by helping him transport the food.

This time, it’s different.

The sticky note lists an entire pitcher of Mydei’s specific pomegranate juice, three of Phainon’s favourite dishes, and the name of a special layer cake traditionally served in the shape of a square: the portokalopita.

While oranges aren’t hard to come by in Okhema, they were difficult to acquire in Kremnos. So difficult, in fact, that the third Kremnoan king made it a routine to move Castrum Kremnos to the orchards of Kédros where they grew in abundance once a year. He even struck a deal with them, offering the finest Kremnoan weaponry and armour in exchange for ten percent of the harvest. Not just because oranges were a rare delicacy, but because his queen mentioned enjoying the juice in passing and wondered how it would taste as a syrup.

It didn’t take long for the portokalopita to be born. Within five harvests, the most skilled bakers in the royal kitchens created the queen’s favourite pastry. Over the centuries, children of Gorgo have used it to subtly accept romantic advances. If not a final answer, then at least an invitation to continue, depending on how early it was served to the suitor.

Pherusa looks up, watching Mydei gingerly place the pan on the stove and stare at it. When he reaches for the ladle and slowly closes his fingers around it, his eyes still boring holes into the pan, she snorts before she can stop herself. He instantly whips his head around with the weakest glare she’s ever seen.

“I’m not laughing at you,” Pherusa says, conspicuously hiding her face with the paper. Her shoulders shake and her lips tremble. “I… promise.”

Mydei groans and turns back around, scooping honeycake batter. “Just let it out and be done with it.”

He doesn’t need to ask her twice. She releases the guffaws stuck in her mouth, still hiding her face just in case, and takes a couple of deep breaths. After clearing her throat, she says, “My apologies. Your order isn’t a problem at all, Mydeimos. I would be honoured to complete it for you.” She grins, lowering the paper. “But you don’t have to be so shy about it! I figured this time would come sooner or later.”

Four honeycakes land in the pan, but she doesn’t hear them sizzle. He doesn’t seem to notice. “Oh, really? Have you been watching us like everyone else seems to be?”

Pherusa flicks a dismissive hand. “I hardly need to. It’s been so long, yet I haven’t heard a word of complaint about him from you. You’re not one to string poor affectionate souls along, are you?”

Mydei huffs. “Of course not.”

“I rest my case.” Pherusa shrugs and returns to her fruit, carefully folding the note into her pocket. “By the way, you might want to check the stove.”

“The stove?” Mydei looks around himself with hovering hands, muttering, “What’s wrong with the stove…?”

Pherusa presses her lips firmly together, cutting strawberries with a wobbly smile. She hears the sharp beep of the stove, frenzied scraping, and an exasperated curse. It’s a miracle that she refrains from laughing at all.

No matter how old he gets or what his hectic life throws at him, he’s still the same boy who struggles to voice his own deep feelings.

~

The aromatic orange syrup spills over the sides of the ladle as Pherusa steadily lifts it out of the bowl. She waits for it to collect at the bottom, dripping back down until the stream slows to a stop, then holds it over the portokalopita for a controlled pour.

This is always the most satisfying part. She wishes she could make soaked cakes every night.

The cold syrup fully sinks into the steaming hot cake, a nice and flavourful splotch, before she goes back for another dip. Another pour. Another dip. Another pour.

All the other dishes are ready and laid out on the wide tray with a pitcher of Mydei's pomegranate juice in the corner. After the cake, the only thing left is to write the note to be served along with it.

She didn't notice it when he first gave her the sticky note, but later that day, she had the mind to flip the paper over and read the other side. The light of Kephale's Dawn Device had shone just right, making the words on the back appear in a faded mirror. There, she found a message he requested to have her write in Kremnoan. It wasn't perfect, but she didn't mind cleaning it up. She knows what it's meant to say.

Once the soaking phase is complete, she places the cake in the icebox for chilling. It doesn't need to be borderline frozen, just cold enough for the syrup to thicken while she finds a pen and paper. Her journey leads her out of the kitchens.

As she walks, she can't help the pride swelling in her chest. She has seen him grow from a tactless yet earnest child into such a well-rounded man that she can hardly believe his progress. He's made friends, lost them, tried again, and ended up meeting his match.

His *true* match.

She hardly needs to speak for the combat side. Their duel when they first met is still brought up around the average Kremnoan dinner table to this day. It's spoken of with wonder, awe, and the utmost respect. More than a few people in the older crowd have nostalgically compared it to the late King Eurypon and Queen Gorgo in their early days.

From what she's seen of them, their personalities complement each other perfectly. They're similar where it matters most and are different enough to

have an interesting dynamic. They exist in such clear harmony that anyone would have a hard time believing they didn't get together sooner.

And now, this is the moment the Kremnoan detachment has been waiting for. Not just because their courtship has set the world wound web on fire, but because it's *Mydeimos.* He's their leader, their king, the man they trust with all their lives, with their beloved nation, with a thousand years of history.

Aside from returning to Kremnos, all so many of them have wished for is to see him happy. After everything he's done for his people, especially since their arrival at Okhema, it's the absolute least he deserves.

Pherusa is certain that his mother, bless her heroic soul, must be smiling in the afterlife.

She stops at a side table at the end of the hallway and tugs on the drawer. Exactly where she thought they'd be.

Taking up a pen, she twirls it in her fingers before writing the message:

May the blade forged of our love, tempered by the hardships we overcome, defeat all who stand in our way.

My blind spots are yours to protect.

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